

**Pinki Khakha, 14****Saudag village, Jharkhand**

Pinki's parents and elder sister were hacked to death after being accused of practising black magic. She escaped her family's fate as she had locked herself up in a room. Three relatives, who held Pinki's parents responsible for the death of their 12-year-old daughter, were arrested. The police, however, also suspects that the relatives' intended to grab the deceased family's property.



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records clarify that the conviction rate of culpable homicide cases (which includes witchcraft killings) in Jharkhand have been less than half the national average—which itself has not even touched 35 per cent during the last nine years. For instance, in 2008, when prosecutors secured convictions in 34.8 per cent cases of culpable homicide, the corresponding conviction rate in Jharkhand remained at only 17.1 per cent.

A low conviction rate is not the only reason why women are still being killed in Jharkhand for practising witchcraft. A strong belief in ghosts, spirits and witches is deeply embedded in Jharkhand society. Poor enforcement of the state's Prevention of Witch Practices Act also follows the

**WOMEN AT A BLACK MAGIC CEREMONY**

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fact that witch-hunting has both religious and social sanction. So strong is the belief in superstition that there are recorded instances like the one at Pakur district in January 2009 in which a man, Misir Murmu (35), hanged his mother Bahamuni Kisku (55) after his siblings died. The village priest also confirmed that the deaths were a result of black magic practised by his mother.

Lack of government health facilities also compels people to fall back on spiritual healers for treatment. When *ojhas* (witch doctors) fail to treat patients through their trial-and-error methods, they invariably blame some defenceless woman. The witch doctor plays on the darkest fears of the human mind. The property rights of women have also led the practice to flourish. The perpetrators, in most cases, are male relatives and their motive is to usurp the property of single women. The female victims are ostracised and are made to give up their property and many of them do not usually seek any legal or police assistance. There are, however, some feisty women like Chhutni Mahtain, 50, who, after being thrown out of her home in 1995 by her husband, has become a crusader against witch-hunting. Since then, she has saved seven alleged witches as a volunteer of an NGO, Free Legal Aid Committee (FLAC).

There have also been instances where women were accused of being witches after they rejected the sexual advances of male neighbours. Also, widows who refuse to relinquish claim over their husband's property are often thrown out after being branded as witches. A FLAC study reveals that over 2,500 women were branded witches and killed in India from 1987 to 2003, of whom around 1,000 were from Bihar and Jharkhand alone.

FLAC President Premchand argues that a central law and effective awareness drives backed with availability of health and educational facilities at the village level are required to check witch-hunt. Vaswi, a noted social activist in Ranchi, explains, "A small group of people brand a woman as a witch, an *ojha* confirms it, and then others join in instigating a crime against her." According to her, traditional communities started branding women as 'witches' when local women healers, known for their wisdom, were seen to become too powerful to be controlled by patriarchal leadership. The witchcraft logic is that, if prayers can heal, they also harm. With the passage of time, the villagers have started blaming anything and everything they don't understand on supernatural powers possessed by women. Witches don't exist, but this brew keeps boiling. ■